

The Official Top Ten

All politicians play the roulette of democracy. The chosen few get to win.

| By Priya Sahgal |

There is nothing more potent and euphoric than the Power of Now. And who would know this better than our politicians who have such a precarious tryst with the ultimate aphrodisiac? Last year's general elections, however, threw up a rare mandate for stability. For the first time since 1984, a government returned to office after completing a full term. That this was a Congress-led coalition only added to the party chief Sonia Gandhi's aura as the Maximum Leader. She has demonstrated rather effectively that real power does not necessarily come from fancy designations. Long ago, she explained her reluctant entry into politics, saying that she could not walk past the portraits of her husband, his mother and grandfather without a sense of "some responsibility to save the party they had given their lives to". Now with the Congress having won a decisive mandate of 207 MPs, she can walk past those portraits with her head held high. In Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, she has given the party of her in-laws a credible present, and in Rahul Gandhi, the Congress also has a future.

A decisive mandate also brings with it the go-ahead to perform. Which is why for the first time, 60 per cent of our Power List belongs to one party: the Congress. For the BJP, this has been a year of both defeat and recovery. With a savvy, pragmatic moderniser taking over the reins, and a younger, more spirited Leader of the Opposition, shades of a saffron resurgence have begun. Amidst all these ambitious central leaders is a chief minister who defies all attempts to bring her down and retains her coveted corner of power. Another regional satrap wields his authority, not by the number of his MPs but by the sheer force of his personality. They use different strategies but they are all playing the same roulette of democracy. And they all play to win.

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SONIA GANDHI

63, Congress President/
UPA Chairperson (1)

